



INSPIRE • NEGOTIATE • LEAD

STUDY GUIDE

UNITED NATIONS HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL



AGENDA:

Protection of Refugees and Internally Displaced Persons *During Armed Conflict*



PROTECT

Uphold the dignity, safety, and rights of all displaced persons.



RESPECT

Ensure respect for international law and human rights principles.



RESPOND

Promote humanitarian access and effective protection mechanisms.



ACCOUNT

Ensure accountability for violations and support justice.



COOPERATE

Strengthen global solidarity and burden-sharing solutions.

“The measure of any society is how it treats those who have been forced to flee.”

– UN High Commissioner for Refugees





UNDERSTANDING THE HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL

The United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC) is the intergovernmental body within the United Nations system responsible for strengthening the promotion and protection of human rights around the globe.



MANDATE & PURPOSE

Established by UN General Assembly resolution 60/251 in 2006, the Human Rights Council has the mandate to:



PROMOTE universal respect for the protection of all human rights and fundamental freedoms for all.



ADDRESS situations of human rights violations and make recommendations on them.



ENGAGE in dialogue and cooperation with states, UN bodies, regional organizations and civil society.



MAKE recommendations to improve the human rights situation in any country.



MONITOR and report on human rights issues, thematic or country-specific.



MEMBERSHIP



47

MEMBER STATES



3-YEAR

TERMS



ELECTED BY

UN GENERAL ASSEMBLY

EQUITABLE geographical representation is ensured through the following seat allocation:



13

AFRICA



13

ASIA-PACIFIC



8

LATIN AMERICA
& CARIBBEAN



7

WESTERN EUROPE
& OTHERS



6

EASTERN EUROPE



Members are elected based on their commitment to the promotion and protection of human rights and must uphold the highest standards.



POWERS & FUNCTIONS



INVESTIGATE – Establish commissions of inquiry and fact-finding missions to investigate alleged human rights violations.



REVIEW – Conduct the Universal Periodic Review (UPR) of all UN Member States every 4.5 years.



RECOMMEND – Issue recommendations and resolutions to promote and protect human rights.



RESPOND – Address emergencies and situations of human rights crises.



ADVISE – Provide advice and technical assistance to build the capacity of states.



REPORT – Produce reports and thematic studies on global human rights issues.



HRC COMPLAINT PROCEDURE

The 1503 Procedure allows individuals or groups to submit complaints of systematic human rights violations.

01



Complaint
Submitted

Alleged victims or representatives submit a written complaint.

02



Initial
Assessment

The Secretariat screens the complaint for admissibility.

03



Working Group
Review

The Working Group on Communications examines the complaint.

04



Decision

If accepted, the Council may examine and act on it.

05



Follow-up

Recommendations and actions are monitored for implementation.



This is a confidential, non-adversarial, and consultative process.



HOW A RESOLUTION IS ADOPTED



Drafting

A member state or group introduces a draft resolution.



Debate

Council members discuss, propose amendments.



Negotiation

Delegates negotiate language and compromise.



Voting

Resolutions are adopted by a simple majority.



Adoption

Adopted resolutions are not legally binding but carry significant moral and political weight.



The Council may also adopt presidential statements, decisions, and other than resolution texts.



UNHRC SESSION STRUCTURE



Regular Sessions

Held three times a year in Geneva (usually Feb-Mar, Jun-Jul, Sep-Oct) for up to 10 weeks each.



Special Sessions

Convened to address urgent human rights situations.



Interactive Dialogues

Engagements with Special Procedures, committees, and country rapporteurs.



Side Events

Organized by states, NGOs and UN entities to highlight key issues.



“All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights. They are endowed with reason and conscience and should act towards one another in a spirit of brotherhood.”

– Universal Declaration of Human Rights, Article 1



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BACKGROUND TO THE AGENDA: REFUGEES, IDPS & ARMED CONFLICT

“ War does not only take lives; it destroys homes, communities, and futures. Protecting those forced to flee is a test of our shared humanity. ”



WHO ARE REFUGEES AND IDPS?



REFUGEES

Persons who have crossed an international border due to a well-founded fear of persecution, conflict, violence, or human rights violations.

Legal basis: 1951 Refugee Convention relating to the Status of Refugees and its 1967 Protocol.



INTERNALLY DISPLACED PERSONS (IDPs)

Persons who have been forced to flee their homes because of conflict, violence, generalized violence, human rights violations, or disasters, but who have not crossed an international border.

Legal basis: UN Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement (1998).



KEY STATISTICS (AS OF EARLY 2026)



**122.6
MILLION+**

Forcibly displaced
worldwide
(1 in 67 people)



**43.7
MILLION+**

Internally displaced
persons (IDPs)



**38.3
MILLION+**

Refugees under UNHCR
mandate



**6.9
MILLION+**

Asylum-seekers



The highest levels ever recorded. Protracted conflicts, climate shocks, and rising inequality are driving displacement to new extremes.

Source: UNHCR Global Trends Report 2025, IOM, Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre (IDMC)



CAUSES OF DISPLACEMENT IN ARMED CONFLICT



Armed Conflict

Civil wars, international conflicts, and fighting between non-state armed groups.



Persecution & Violence

Ethnic, religious, racial or political persecution and targeted violence.



Human Rights Violations

Torture, extrajudicial killings, arbitrary detention, sexual violence, and other abuses.



Breakdown of Law & Order

Collapse of governance, weak institutions, and impunity.



Climate & Environmental Factors

Droughts, floods, and environmental degradation exacerbate vulnerabilities.



Economic Collapse

Poverty, unemployment, and resource scarcity fuel instability.



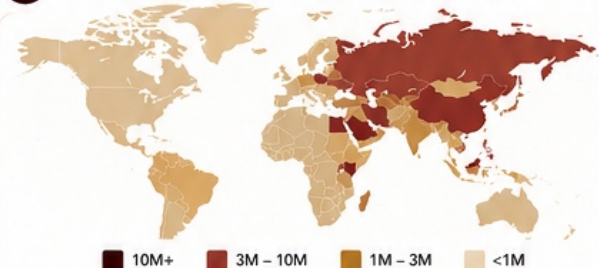
MAJOR ONGOING DISPLACEMENT CRISES

CRISIS	REFUGEES (MILLION+)	IDPS (MILLION+)	KEY DRIVERS
Sudan	3.2	11.3	Armed conflict, ethnic violence, humanitarian collapse
Ukraine	6.8	3.7	Armed conflict, attacks on civilians, occupation
Afghanistan	6.4	0.6	Conflict, human rights restrictions, economic crisis
Syria	6.3	6.9	Protracted conflict, destruction, insecurity
Myanmar	1.5	3.6	Armed conflict, political instability, persecution
Gaza (OPT)	–	1.9*	Ongoing hostilities, blockade, humanitarian emergency

*IDPs within Gaza are estimated; majority of the population is internally displaced.



WHERE DISPLACED PEOPLE COME FROM



Most displacement occurs in low- and middle-income countries, which host the majority of the world's refugees.



FACTORS THAT DEEPEN VULNERABILITY



Women & Children

Face higher risks of gender-based violence, exploitation, and lack of access to services.



Persons with Disabilities

Face significant barriers to safety, information, and humanitarian aid.



Minorities & Indigenous Peoples

Disproportionately affected by discrimination and exclusion.



Urban Displacement

Growing number of IDPs in cities struggle with protection and livelihoods.



KEY TAKEAWAY

Displacement is both a humanitarian and human rights crisis. Protecting refugees and IDPs during armed conflict requires upholding international law, ensuring accountability, and addressing root causes.



“ To be forced to leave your home is to be stripped of more than shelter—it is to lose security, identity, and hope. ”

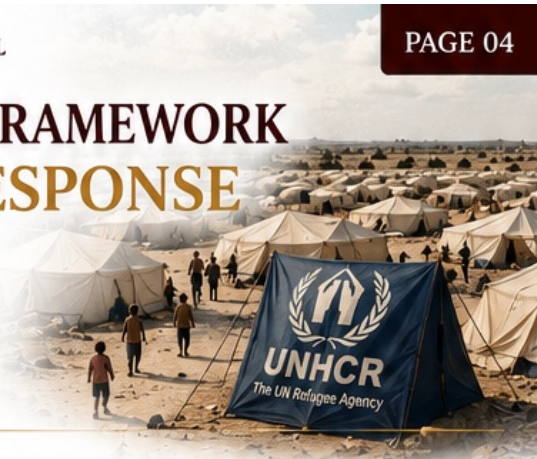
— António Guterres, UN Secretary-General



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INTERNATIONAL LEGAL FRAMEWORK & HUMANITARIAN RESPONSE

The protection of refugees and internally displaced persons during armed conflict is grounded in international law, human rights principles, and the collective action of states, UN bodies, and humanitarian organizations.



INTERNATIONAL LEGAL FRAMEWORK

INTERNATIONAL HUMANITARIAN LAW (IHL)	1951 REFUGEE CONVENTION & 1967 PROTOCOL	GUIDING PRINCIPLES ON INTERNAL DISPLACEMENT (1998)	INTERNATIONAL HUMAN RIGHTS LAW (IHRL)
 Applies during armed conflict to protect persons who are not, or are no longer, participating in hostilities. Key Principles: ✓ Distinction ✓ Proportionality ✓ Precaution ✓ Humanity	 Define who a refugee is and outline the rights and obligations of refugees and states. Core Rights: ✓ Non-refoulement ✓ Right to asylum ✓ Access to courts ✓ Right to work & education	 The authoritative framework on the protection of IDPs within their own country. Key Protections: ✓ Right to safety & dignity ✓ Freedom of movement ✓ Right to adequate housing ✓ Right to return	 Applies in all circumstances and complements IHL in protecting the rights of all persons. Relevant Rights: ✓ Right to life ✓ Freedom from torture ✓ Right to health ✓ Right to an adequate standard of living



HUMANITARIAN ACTORS & THEIR ROLES

 UNHCR (United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees)	Leads international action to protect refugees, seekers of asylum and stateless persons. Provides shelter, legal aid, registration, and durable solutions (return, local integration, resettlement).
 OCHA (UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs)	Coordinates humanitarian response in crises, mobilizes aid, supports clusters, and ensures humanitarian access and protection.
 ICRC (International Committee of the Red Cross)	Works in conflict zones to protect and assist victims of armed conflict; promotes IHL compliance and supports detained persons and their families.
 UNICEF (United Nations Children's Fund)	Protects children affected by conflict and displacement; provides education, healthcare, psychosocial support, and child protection services.
 WFP (World Food Programme)	Provides emergency food assistance, nutritional support, and logistics in displacement and refugee settings.



REGIONAL & OTHER KEY STAKEHOLDERS

REGIONAL ORGANIZATIONS	
 African Union (AU)	Promotes protection standards through the 1969 OAU Convention and the Kampala Convention on IDPs.
 European Union (EU)	Supports protection, resettlement, humanitarian aid, and peacebuilding initiatives globally.
 Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC)	Provides humanitarian assistance and advocates for the protection of vulnerable populations.
 League of Arab States	Supports political solutions and humanitarian responses in the Arab region.
INTERNATIONAL & LOCAL NGOS	
 Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF)	Delivers medical humanitarian aid in conflict and displacement settings.
 International Rescue Committee (IRC)	Provides emergency relief, protection, and recovery programs for displaced populations.
 Norwegian Refugee Council (NRC)	Supports IDPs through shelter, education, legal aid, and advocacy.
 Local Civil Society Organizations	Play a vital role in protection monitoring, aid delivery, and community support on the ground.



KEY CHALLENGES IN PROTECTING REFUGEES & IDPs

 Protracted & Complex Conflicts Conflicts drag on for years, causing repeated displacement and worsening conditions.	 Lack of Political Will Some states do not prioritize protection obligations or humanitarian access.	 Weak Implementation of Laws International laws exist but are poorly implemented or enforced.	 Underfunded Responses Humanitarian appeals are chronically underfunded, limiting aid coverage.	 Restricted Access Blockades, insecurity and bureaucracy prevent aid workers from reaching those in need.	 Targeting of Civilians & Aid Workers Attacks on civilians, refugees, and humanitarian workers continue with impunity.	 Climate Change & Environmental Risks Droughts, floods, and environmental degradation increase displacement and vulnerability.
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BEST PRACTICES & PROMISING APPROACHES

- ✓ Adopt whole-of-government approaches to protection and solutions.
- ✓ Ensure meaningful participation of refugees, IDPs and affected communities.
- ✓ Invest in prevention and early warning systems.
- ✓ Promote durable solutions: safe return, local integration, and resettlement.
- ✓ Strengthen data collection and protection monitoring.
- ✓ Prioritize protection in humanitarian funding and planning.



The safety, dignity and rights of refugees and IDPs are not acts of charity — they are binding legal obligations and a test of our common humanity.



"In times of war, the worst suffering is not only caused by weapons, but by forgetting our shared humanity."
— UN Secretary-General





COMMITTEE PREPARATION: DEBATE. NEGOTIATE. IMPACT.

Use this guide to prepare effectively as a delegate, understand your country's position, and contribute to meaningful solutions.



BLOC POSITIONS & INTERESTS

BLOC / GROUP	KEY MEMBERS (EXAMPLES)	INTERESTS & APPROACH
Western European & Others (WEOG)		- Strong protection of human rights - Accountability for violations - Support for resource mobilization - Rule of law & multilateralism
Eastern European Group (EEG)		- Sovereignty with responsibility - Protection of civilians - Focus on durable solutions - Post-conflict recovery
Asia-Pacific Group (APG)		- Non-interference & sovereignty - Development & humanitarian aid - Balanced approach to mandates - Capacity building support
Latin American & Caribbean Group (GRULAC)		- Human rights with development - Equality & non-discrimination - Solidarity with affected states - Support for cooperation
African Group		- African-led solutions - Protection of sovereignty - Humanitarian access & aid - Address root causes
Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC)		- Respect for sovereignty - Non-selectivity in human rights - Oppose politicization - Support for OIC initiatives

★ Build coalitions early, identify common ground, and be flexible.

RESOLUTION WRITING GUIDE

PREAMBULATORY Clauses	Set the context. Refer to past resolutions, international law, and principles. Example: <i>Recalling...</i> , <i>Deeply concerned by...</i> , <i>Recognizing...</i> , <i>Emphasizing...</i>
OPERATIVE Clauses	Propose concrete actions and solutions. Use action-oriented verbs. Example: <i>Calls upon...</i> , <i>Urges...</i> , <i>Encourages...</i> , <i>Requests...</i> , <i>Decides...</i>
IMPLEMENTATION Clauses	Define how the resolution will be implemented and by whom. Example: <i>Requests the High Commissioner to...</i> , <i>Encourages states to...</i> , <i>Invites...</i>
FINAL Clauses	Include follow-up, reporting, and review mechanisms. Example: <i>Decides to remain seized of the matter.</i>

SAMPLE OPERATIVE CLAUSES

1. Calls upon all parties to armed conflict to respect and uphold their obligations under international humanitarian law and international human rights law.
2. Urges states to ensure the protection of refugees and IDPs, especially women, children, and persons with disabilities.
3. Encourages the establishment of safe corridors and humanitarian access to reach affected populations.
4. Requests the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights to monitor and report on human rights violations affecting refugees and IDPs.
5. Calls for increased funding and resources to support host communities and humanitarian agencies.
6. Urges states to implement durable solutions that ensure voluntary, safe, dignified, and sustainable return or local integration.

MOTIONS IN UNHRC

Point of Order	Point of Information	Right of Reply	Motion to Amend	Motion to Divide the Question	Motion to Close Debate
Raised for issues related to the rules or procedure.	To request clarification on a statement or point.	Allows a delegate to respond to personal attacks.	Propose changes to a draft resolution.	Vote separately on parts of a draft resolution.	Propose the end of debate and move to voting.

💡 Use motions strategically and respectfully to keep debate focused and productive.

KEY QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

- How can the Council ensure the protection of civilians while respecting state sovereignty?
- What measures can be implemented to ensure accountability for human rights violations?
- How can the international community support durable solutions for refugees and IDPs?
- What role should humanitarian organizations play in conflict-affected regions?
- How can funding gaps be addressed to meet the growing humanitarian needs?
- How can early warning systems and diplomacy help prevent displacement?

POSSIBLE SOLUTIONS

- ✓ Strengthen compliance with IHL and IHRL through monitoring and reporting.
- ✓ Ensure safe, dignified, and voluntary return, local integration, or resettlement.
- ✓ Increase humanitarian funding and predictable financial commitments.
- ✓ Promote inclusive governance and address root causes of conflict.
- ✓ Support host communities and build their resilience and capacities.
- ✓ Enhance protection for vulnerable groups, especially women and children.
- ✓ Develop early warning systems and conflict prevention mechanisms.
- ✓ Encourage regional cooperation and burden-sharing arrangements.

USEFUL DEBATE STRATEGIES

- Know Your Country**
Understand your policies, priorities, and past statements.
- Listen to Others**
Listen to others and note areas of agreement.
- Speak with Purpose**
Be concise, clear, and solution-oriented.
- Build Alliances**
Engage in informal consultations and build coalitions.
- Be Flexible**
Negotiate and compromise where possible.

DELEGATE CHECKLIST

- ☐ Research your country's position and interests.
- ☐ Understand the agenda and key terminology.
- ☐ Review past resolutions and current developments.
- ☐ Identify regional, political, and humanitarian priorities.
- ☐ Prepare opening speech (1-1.5 minutes).
- ☐ List 3-5 key points your country wants to address.
- ☐ Identify potential allies and partners.
- ☐ Bring facts, statistics, and credible sources.
- ☐ Prepare ideas for solutions and amendments.
- ☐ Remain respectful, diplomatic, and inclusive.

TIPS FOR EFFECTIVE DELEGATES

Base arguments on facts, law, and precedents.	Use diplomatic language and avoid accusatory terms.	Focus on solutions, not just highlighting problems.	Stay on topic and respect the speaking time.	Engage constructively and encourage participation.	Think globally, act responsibly, impact locally.
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“Effective diplomacy is the bridge between compassion and change. Let your words protect, your solutions heal, and your actions inspire hope.”



YOUR VOICE CAN PROTECT A LIFE.
YOUR RESOLUTION CAN RESTORE HOPE.
YOUR LEADERSHIP CAN BUILD PEACE.



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APPENDIX & QUICK REFERENCE

KNOWLEDGE. PREPARATION. IMPACT.

“No one leaves home unless home is the mouth of a shark.”
– Warsan Shire



IMPORTANT INTERNATIONAL TREATIES & INSTRUMENTS

- 1948 Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR)
- 1951 Refugee Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees
- 1967 Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees
- 1949 Geneva Conventions (I–IV)
- 1977 Additional Protocols I & II to the Geneva Conventions
- 1984 Convention Against Torture (CAT)
- 1998 Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement
- 2000 Optional Protocol to the Convention Against Torture (OPCAT)
- 2005 Responsibility to Protect (R2P) – World Summit Outcome Document
- 2010 Kampala Convention (Protection & Assistance of IDPs in Africa)



These instruments form the legal backbone for the protection of refugees and IDPs during armed conflict.



KEY TERMINOLOGY



Refugee: A person who has crossed an international border due to a well-founded fear of persecution, conflict, violence or human rights violations.



Internally Displaced Person (IDP): A person forced to flee their home but who has not crossed an international border.



Asylum-Seeker: A person who has left their country seeking international protection and whose claim has not yet been determined.



Durable Solutions: Long-term solutions to displacement, including voluntary return, local integration, or resettlement in a third country.



Non-Refoulement: The principle of not returning anyone to a territory where their life or freedom would be threatened.



Humanitarian Aid: Assistance provided to meet the basic needs and protect the rights of affected populations.



TIMELINE OF KEY DEVELOPMENTS

- 1948 UDHR adopted by the UN General Assembly
- 1949 Geneva Conventions adopted
- 1951 Refugee Convention adopted
- 1967 Refugee Protocol adopted
- 1977 Additional Protocols I & II adopted
- 1992 UNHCR Executive Committee Conclusion on IDPs
- 1998 Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement endorsed
- 2000 UNHCR adopts Agenda for Protection
- 2005 R2P endorsed by World Summit
- 2011 UNHRC strengthens its focus on situations of displacement
- 2026 Ongoing global commitment to protect refugees & IDPs in line with international law and human dignity



Human Rights Glossary (Selected)



Right to Life

Everyone has the right to life, liberty and security of person.



Freedom from Torture

No one shall be subjected to torture or to cruel, inhuman or degrading treatment or punishment.



Right to Seek Asylum

Everyone has the right to seek and enjoy asylum from persecution in other countries.



Right to Adequate Housing

Everyone has the right to an adequate standard of living, including housing, in times of displacement.



Right to Health

Everyone has the right to the highest attainable standard of physical and mental health.



Right to Education

Every child has the right to education, even in situations of displacement.



RESEARCH CHECKLIST

- ☐ Understand your country's history and involvement in conflicts and displacement.
- ☐ Review national laws and refugee/IDP policies.
- ☐ Identify key humanitarian challenges faced by your country.
- ☐ Analyze past UNHRC resolutions on the agenda.
- ☐ Research your country's voting record in UNHRC.
- ☐ Identify alliances and regional positions.
- ☐ Gather statistics and recent developments (2024–2026).
- ☐ Explore national efforts for refugee & IDP protection.
- ☐ Prepare data, case studies and examples.
- ☐ Consult UN reports (UNHCR, OCHA, OHCHR, ICRC).
- ☐ Stay updated on current humanitarian situations.



DELEGATE QUICK REMINDERS

- ✓ **Be Informed:** Know your facts, laws, and country position.
- ✓ **Be Respectful:** Listen to others and respect different perspectives.
- ✓ **Be Constructive:** Focus on solutions, not blame.
- ✓ **Be Diplomatic:** Use formal, inclusive, and moderate language.
- ✓ **Be Active:** Participate in debates and express your ideas clearly.
- ✓ **Be Cooperative:** Build consensus and work towards common ground.
- ✓ **Be Impactful:** Your words today can inspire change tomorrow.



USEFUL DATA SOURCES



UNHCR
(United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees)



ICRC
(International Committee of the Red Cross)



OCHA
(UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs)



UNDP
(United Nations Development Programme)



OHCHR
(Office of the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights)



World Bank – Forced Displacement Analytics



IDMC
(Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre)



Global Protection Cluster (GPC)



Always cross-check information from multiple credible sources.

FINAL WORDS

As delegates of the Human Rights Council, you carry the responsibility to uphold the dignity, rights and hopes of millions who have been forced to flee.

Let your debates be rooted in empathy, your arguments in facts, and your solutions in humanity.

“THE MEASURE OF ANY SOCIETY IS HOW IT TREATS THOSE WHO HAVE NOTHING, NO VOICE, AND NO POWER.”

– Unknown



TO PROTECT HUMANITY IS TO PROTECT OUR FUTURE.
DEBATE WITH PURPOSE. NEGOTIATE WITH EMPATHY. LEAD WITH IMPACT.



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